

Oral Presentations

Abstract Plenary

OP0001

COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS OF SYNOVIAL TISSUE TOPOGRAPHY BY SINGLE CELL TRANSCRIPTOMICS AND SPATIAL TRANSCRIPTOMICS REVEALS DISCRETE AND OVERLAPPING DISEASE PATHWAYS DRIVING CHECKPOINT INHIBITOR-INDUCED AND SPONTANEOUS INFLAMMATORY ARTHRITIS

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J. D. Turner¹, A. K. McLean², A. Thomson³, K. Williams², I. Nicorescu², L. Jones¹, G. Mercres³, A. Teodosio⁴, B. Hunter³, J. McMurray⁴, S. Gilbert⁴, A. Degnan², D. Scheel-Toellner¹, S. Jariwala⁵, Q. An⁵, R. Plummer⁸, A. P. Croft¹, L. Pallan⁹, B. A. Fisher¹, J. Coxhead², R. Hussain³, M. Magid-Slav⁶, D. McDonald³, S. Siebert⁶, A. Filby³, G. Reynolds¹⁰, A. E. Anderson², C. Hilkens², D. F. Tough⁷, A. Filer^{1,4}, A. Pratt¹. ¹University of Birmingham, Rheumatology Research Group, Birmingham, United Kingdom; ²Newcastle University, Translational and Clinical Research Institute, Newcastle upon Tyne, United Kingdom; ³Newcastle University, Flow Cytometry Core Facility, Newcastle upon Tyne, United Kingdom; ⁴University of Birmingham, Birmingham Tissue Analytics, Birmingham, United Kingdom; ⁵GSK, Human Genetics & Genomics, Collegeville, United States of America; ⁶University of Glasgow, School of Infection & Immunity, Glasgow, United Kingdom; ⁷GSK, Respiratory & Immunology Research Unit, Stevenage, United Kingdom; ⁸Newcastle upon Tyne Hospitals, Bobby Robson Unit, Newcastle upon Tyne, United Kingdom; ⁹University Hospitals Birmingham NHS Foundation Trust, Department of Oncology, Birmingham, United Kingdom; ¹⁰Massachusetts General Hospital, Center for Immunology and Inflammatory Diseases, Boston, United States of America

Background: Anti-citrullinated peptide autoantibody seropositive rheumatoid arthritis (SPRA) and psoriatic arthritis (PsA) are relatively well-characterised disease phenotypes for which a growing number of rational therapies target defined pathways. Other forms of seronegative immune-mediated inflammatory arthritis (SIA) – including undifferentiated inflammatory arthritis and seronegative RA – are more heterogeneous in presentation, difficult to classify and lack rational treatment strategies. Immune checkpoint inhibitor-induced inflammatory arthritis (ICI-IA), which develops in ≥6% cancer patients treated with ICIs, shares many clinical characteristics with SIA and is similarly under-represented in interventional clinical trials.

Objectives: Identify common and unique disease mechanisms of SIA and ICI-IA with SPRA and PsA, as potential targetable disease pathways for patients poorly served by existing treatments.

Methods: Synovial tissues were obtained from patients who were naïve to glucocorticoids or disease modifying anti-rheumatic drugs across two recruitment sites. Human biological samples were sourced ethically, and their research use was in accord with the terms of the informed consents under a REC approved protocol. Single-cell RNA-Seq was performed using the 10X platform after enzymatic disaggregation [1] and live cell sorting. Paired paraffin-embedded tissues were haematoxylin and eosin (H+E)-stained and scored for synovitis severity [2]. Xenium spatial transcriptomics is currently underway for a subset of these samples.

Results: Synovitis severity did not differ significantly between disease phenotypes (median Krenn score 5). 138,676 cells were sequenced from 36 individuals (11 SPRA, 7 PsA, 9 SIA and 9 ICI-IA) with major cell lineages clearly delineated following normalisation, clustering and annotation (Figure 1A). Considering relative cellular abundance, a higher proportion of ICI-IA tissues fell within a “fibroblast dominant” (as opposed to myeloid and/or T cell-dominant) cluster, compared with those from participants with “spontaneous” arthritis (45% versus 7%; p=0.024, Fisher’s Exact test). In addition, ICI-IA tissues exhibited a significant preponderance of the endothelial cell markers *PODXL*, *KDR* and *ACKR1* compared with those of comparator groups (5% false discovery rate [3]; Figure 1B). Correspondingly, inferred contact [4] between fibroblasts and endothelial cells was significantly enhanced in ICI-IA compared to either SPRA or PsA, and a similar pattern was observed for SIA, albeit less marked (Figure 1C). Other predicted disease group-specific cellular interactions included dendritic cells (DC) with CD8+ T-cells in ICI-IA, and gene set enrichment analysis highlighted relatively enhanced TNF signalling in memory CD8+ T cells (BH-corrected p=5.21 × 10⁻⁵), reflecting a pattern in the synovium more generally; indeed, module scoring suggested this significantly exceeded that observed in SPRA (p=3.02⁻⁴⁹; Figure 1D). Spatial corroboration of these and other putative interactions at a transcript level by Xenium analysis is ongoing (Figure 1E).

Conclusion: Our preliminary findings highlight aspects of synovial pathobiology in ICI-IA that are shared to varying degrees with spontaneous arthritis

subtypes. These insights already provide pathobiological support to the current use of TNF inhibitors as a treatment for ICI-IA and could guide the development of targeted treatment strategies for both ICI-IA and SIA in the future.

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Figure 1

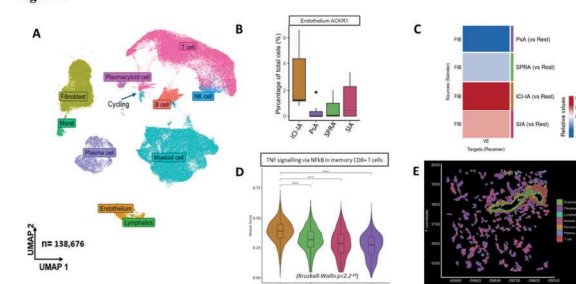


Figure 1. A. UMAP indicating major cell subsets following normalisation, clustering and annotation. **B.** Proportional abundance of ACR1-expressing endothelial cells across diagnostic categories. **C.** Heatmap comparing interaction strength between fibroblasts (FIB) and vascular endothelial (VE) cells across arthritides. **D.** Violin plot comparing gene module scoring of TNF Signalling via NF-κB (MSigDB Hallmark) in CD8+ memory cells across arthritides; module scores calculated using the Seurat ‘AddModuleScore1’ function (Kruskal-Wallis with Dunn’s post hoc). **E.** Synovial spatial transcriptomics displaying perivascular fibroblast association.

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